

Check-In / Check-Out System — Security Review

A plain-language summary of what was found and what needs to happen next.

The short version

This is a system that tracks children checking in and out (for example, at a school or program). It handles real information about real kids and their parents. Right now, this system **should not be used with real families** until the problems below are fixed. The three most urgent problems are:

- Real children's names and their parents' phone numbers have been posted somewhere anyone on the internet can see them.
- The database that stores everything is completely unlocked — anyone online can read it, change it, or delete it, including the staff passwords.
- Logging in can be bypassed. There are hidden shortcuts that let someone get into the admin account without knowing the real password.

Problems that need fixing right away

1. Staff and admin passwords are out in the open

The admin username and password, and a staff password, are written directly into the program's code, which is publicly visible online. Anyone who finds it can log in as the administrator. If that admin password is one the person also uses anywhere else, that personal password should be considered exposed too.

2. A secret "master password" lets anyone log in

On top of the exposed passwords, there's a built-in shortcut: typing the word "password" logs you into almost any account. The list of usernames is easy to see, so this means anyone can get into the admin dashboard without knowing any real password.

3. The database has no lock on the door

The system that stores all the data (student records, attendance, staff accounts) is set up so that absolutely anyone, anywhere, can read it, change it, or erase it — no login required. The connection details needed to reach that database are also public. In short, this data is already exposed and should be treated as compromised.

4. Real children's personal information is exposed publicly

The real names, ID numbers, and parents' phone numbers for about 103 real children are stored in the public copy of the code (in a spreadsheet-style file and in the program itself), and this same data automatically gets reloaded into the database every time the app starts. This is a serious privacy issue for children's data and could expose families to unwanted contact.

5. Staff passwords are stored as plain, readable text

Passwords are not stored securely — they're saved as plain text, and copies of them get sent to every browser that uses the app and saved on the device. On a shared computer (like a check-in kiosk), anyone using that computer could pull out staff passwords.

6. Releasing a child to someone requires no real verification

When a staff member "approves" releasing a child to a pickup person, the system only asks them to pick their own name from a drop-down list — no password, no PIN, nothing that actually proves who is approving it. This means anyone at the check-in screen (or anyone who can reach the database) could release a child to whoever they choose. This defeats the entire safety purpose of the system.

Other notable problems

Beyond the six urgent issues above, the review also found a longer list of smaller — but still real — issues, including:

- Logging in doesn't properly check with the real authentication service, so old, deleted, or disabled accounts can still get in, and someone could trick their browser into granting themselves admin access.
- Anyone can create an email address containing the word "admin" and the system will automatically treat them as an administrator.
- Checking a child in or out only requires typing a name — there's no photo, PIN, or ID card check, so one child could easily be checked in as another.
- The system marks text messages to parents as "sent" even though no actual text message service is connected — parents may be told they were notified when they weren't.
- Some maintenance scripts can wipe out real student records automatically, with no warning or confirmation step.
- The full list of students, attendance, and staff passwords sits saved on shared kiosk devices even after someone logs out.

What should happen next

The recommended order of action is:

- 1 Change the admin and staff passwords immediately, and change them anywhere else they may have been reused personally.
- 2 Permanently remove the exposed children's data and passwords from the public code, not just from the current version but from its entire history.
- 3 Lock down the database so only verified staff logins can read or change it.
- 4 Remove the hidden password shortcuts so the only way in is with a real, verified password.
- 5 Require real verification (like a PIN or a second login step) before a child can be released to someone.

- 6 Stop storing passwords in plain text anywhere, including on shared devices.
- 7 Turn off the automatic scripts that can erase real student data without warning.
- 8 Either connect a real text-messaging service, or stop telling parents a message was sent when it wasn't.

Bottom line: this system should be treated as not safe for real use until the password, database, and verification issues above are fixed, and the exposed children's data should be treated as already breached.